



BRINGING IT HOME
Images of Subodh Gupta's installations at his latest exhibition, *Cosmic Battle*

Subodh Gupta's show *Cosmic Battle* (on view at the Nature Morte gallery, New Delhi until April 10) includes a kinetic sculpture he has named 'Self-portrait'. As often happens with Gupta's art, this work, too, is made up of several cooking utensils. With the artist or his face nowhere to be seen, the question asks itself: How is this a self-portrait? "It's an ode to my childhood memories," Gupta tells us. "As a child, I remember my mother performing elaborate *pooja* with bricks, sand, rice, mango leaves, coconuts and some flowers arranged on a brass *thali*. We grew up with such rituals which were like installation/ performance art for us. This self-portrait is a *jugalbandi* between me and my mother."

'Self-portrait' has been refashioned from aluminium, brass and stainless steel—everyday materials that Gupta, 58, has been using for the last three decades to examine his roots. Collectors today stump up millions to acquire his interpretations of both the world and the great Indian kitchen. Gupta's preferred term for his art is "naturally theatrical". A theatre artist in college, Gupta's concepts have always been informed by ideas of performance. "I don't miss being an actor at all. That was a phase in my life. Now, I create drama through my sculptures. I now perform through my paintings," he laughs.

For Gupta, the kitchen utensil is more than plain metaphor. He says, "In one of his poems, Sant Kabir writes about an earthen pot inside which he found the creator and stars. I think this idea sits very well with my sculptures." Gupta also believes that every utensil contains in it a different multitude of stories: "Old utensils have so much character. Imagine the many individuals who have eaten food in it. I don't know them personally but I can guess who they are. That's why you see dents and marks on the plates. It's like the human palm. When you take a photograph of a palm, it looks like the cosmos."

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Though Gupta usually creates his large-scale works in his Gurugram studio, he also sometimes outsources them to production houses abroad—in countries like China, South Korea, the US and Germany. He is eager to dispel the notion that his works are all gargantuan. "In my entire career, I must have hardly done 20-30 large sculptures. The rest are all smaller works, many of them happen to be paintings." Originally trained as a painter, he says, "I enjoy painting very much. In fact, in between outdoor sculptures, I simply paint when I find time." Would Gupta return to the canvas if there was no market pressure to consistently churn out larger-than-life art? "I don't

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